

Checkout usability study

Why first-time buyers abandon at payment (FICTIONAL EXAMPLE DATA)

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NOTE

Fictional example. This report uses invented data (a made-up online store and made-up participants) to demonstrate the report structure and the HTML renderer. Do not cite any figure in it.

Executive summary

Purpose: understand why first-time buyers abandon the online store at the payment step.

Answer: people abandon because they discover the shipping cost only on the last step. Showing it from the cart is the highest-impact, lowest-effort change.

INSIGHT

5 of 8 interview participants mentioned the late shipping cost unprompted, and 4 of 6 stalled at step 3 of the usability test.

RECOMMENDATION

Show the estimated shipping cost in the cart, and prioritize it in the next cycle.

Decision requested: prioritize recommendation 1 before the October planning, owner: Product.

1. Purpose and objectives

- Learn why first-time buyers drop out between cart and payment.
- Find out which parts of the checkout cause hesitation or errors.
- Decide what to change first.

Hypothesis (before the study): the payment form is too long.

2. Key product metrics

Metric	Value (fictional)	Source
Checkout abandonment	68%	Product analytics, Q3
Abandonment at the payment step	41%	Product analytics, Q3
First-time buyers share of traffic	55%	Product analytics, Q3

3. Methodology

Method	Participants	Dates	Mode
Semi-structured interviews	8	1-12 Sept 2026	Remote, 45 min
Moderated usability test	6	15-19 Sept 2026	Remote, 30 min

Tasks in the test: find a product, filter by size, add to cart, pay as a guest.

4. Participants

14 sessions with first-time buyers (not 14 different people: 2 took part in both). Recruited from a customer list; mixed ages, 10 on desktop and 4 on mobile web.

> **RISK**
>
> **Limits.** Small qualitative sample; mobile was barely covered. Read every "X of N" as a pattern, not as a population percentage.

5. Findings

5.1 The shipping cost appears late and surprises people

Finding: the cost shows up only on the last step, after people have already decided to buy.

Evidence: 5 of 8 interviewees mentioned it unprompted; 4 of 6 stalled at step 3 of the test.

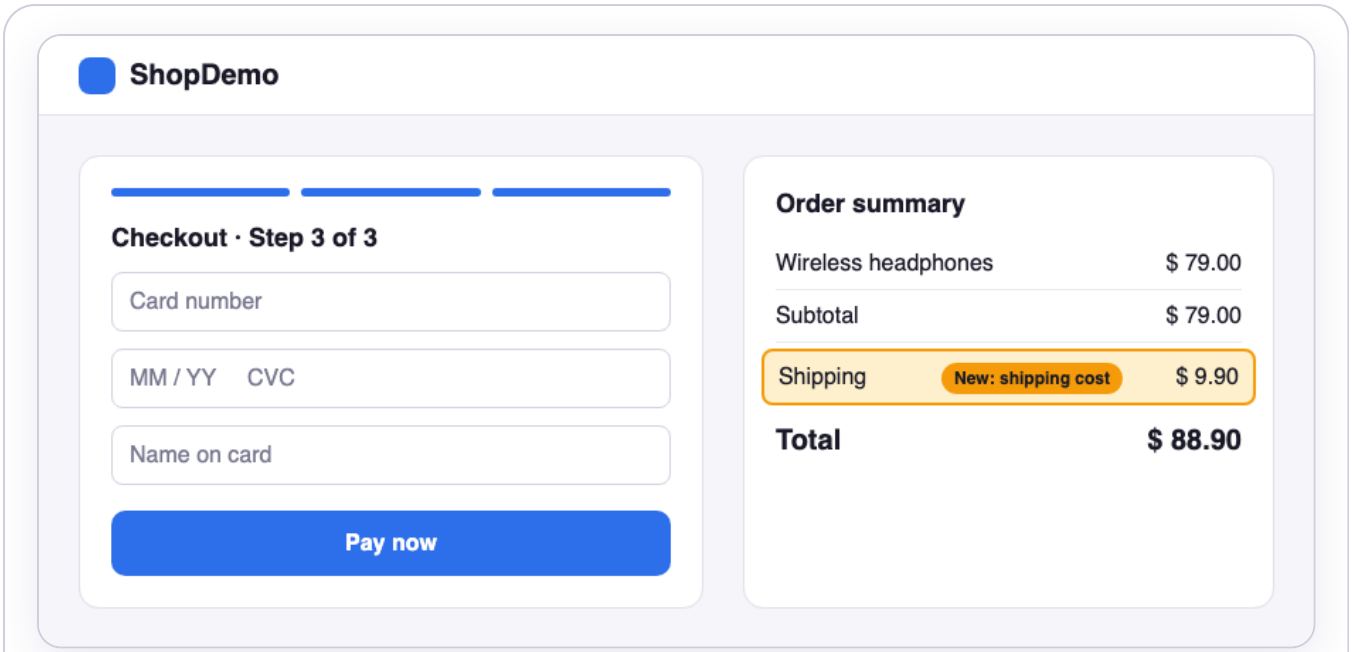


Figure 1. What is seen: the shipping cost ($9.90) appears for the first time in the last step. Why it matters: 4 of 6 participants stalled here. Source: usability test prototype (fictional).

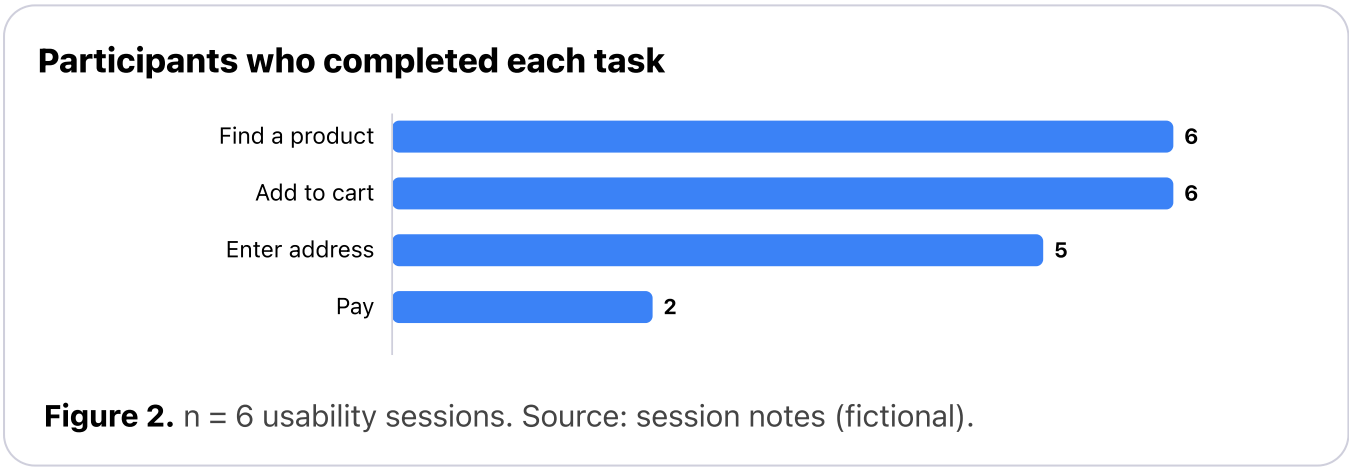


Figure 2. n = 6 usability sessions. Source: session notes (fictional).

> *When I saw the total I thought: this isn't what they told me.*

— P4, first-time buyer, interview

> *I almost closed the tab right there.*

— P11, first-time buyer, usability test

Implication: the surprise is the main trigger of abandonment in this sample.

5.2 After the surprise, people distrust the rest of the payment

3 of 8 hesitated to enter their card after seeing the surcharge. This is a **single-source signal** (interviews only); it was not observed in the tests and needs cross-checking.

5.3 Filters are a real but secondary problem

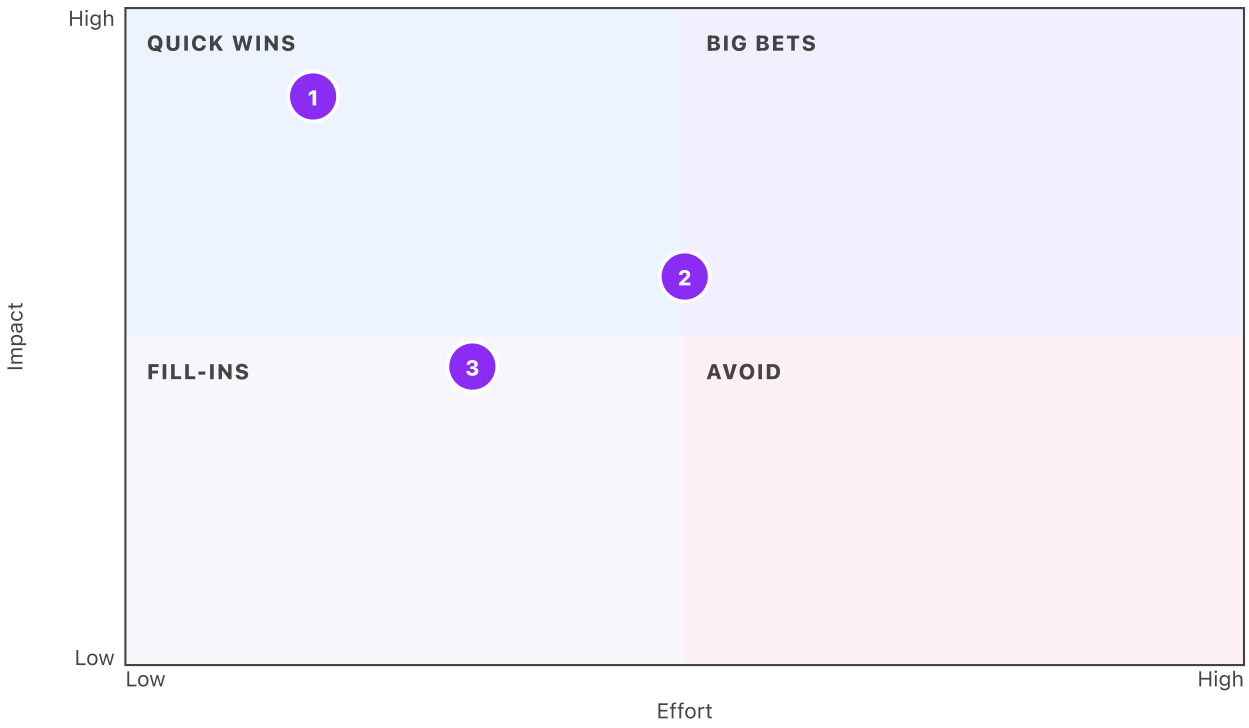
Filters were barely mentioned, although 5 of 6 test participants could not find the size filter.

- Severity: hinders (people finished the task after a long search).
- Frequency: 5 of 6 in the test.
- Not a reason to abandon in this sample.

6. Recommendations

#	Recommendation	Evidence	Impact	Effort	Priority
R1	Show the estimated shipping cost in the cart	5/8 interviews, 4/6 test	High	Low (to confirm)	1
R2	Test a version with the total always visible at payment	3/8 interviews	Medium	Medium	2
R3	Move the filters to the listing header and repeat the test	5/6 test	Medium	Low	3

Recommendations by impact and effort



1. R1 Show the estimated shipping cost in the cart
2. R2 Keep the total always visible at payment
3. R3 Move the filters to the listing header

Figure 3. Placement is the team's estimate, to be confirmed with engineering.

How might we show the total cost from the cart so nobody is surprised at payment?

- [x] R1 acceptance criterion defined: the cart shows the estimated shipping cost before the first payment step.
- [ ] Engineering estimate for R1.
- [ ] Follow-up test with 5-6 people after the change.

7. What we do not know

- Whether it happens the same way on mobile (not tested).
- How much of the measured abandonment this explains.

Next study: mobile test with 5-6 people and a review of the payment-step analytics.

8. Appendices

1. Interview guide
2. Test script and tasks
3. Consent form
4. Codebook and link to the research repository

Verbatim quotes are fictional. Participants are pseudonymized (P4, P11).

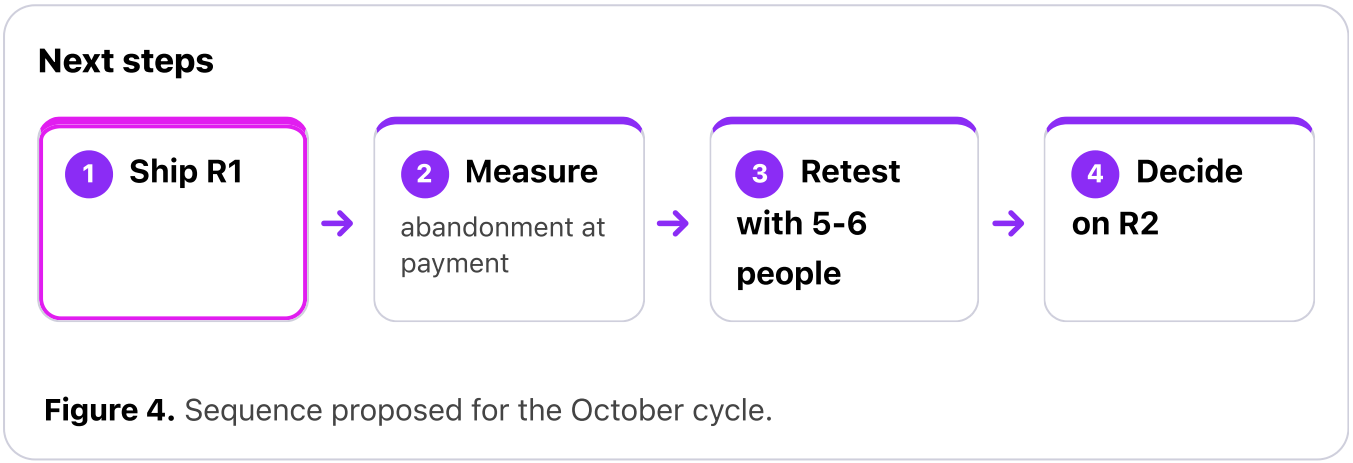


Figure 4. Sequence proposed for the October cycle.

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